

Bribe Boomerang

The arrest of a minister, already a suspect in a murder case, on bribery charges is likely to become a key factor in the coming polls

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Mukul Pathak had just one big dream in his life—to become an Assam Public Service Commission (APSC) officer. He was quite close to achieving his goal. In fact, the results of this year's APSC preliminary examinations were reportedly delayed to accommodate his name in the success list. He received this favour, thanks to his closeness to Assam Education Minister Ripun Bora.

But this closeness spelt doom for this APSC aspirant who was working as a reporter for an Assamese daily. Today, he is rotting in Delhi's Tihar Jail following his arrest by CBI for acting as a conduit to broker a deal between Bora and A.B. Gupta, DCP, Eastern Range, CBI. The Central agency arrested Bora and his accomplice, a Delhi-based businessman Ramesh Maheswari, on June 3 for allegedly trying to bribe Gupta Rs 10 lakh. Bora, a suspect in the murder of political rival Daniel Toppo in 2000, wanted a clean chit from CBI. The prime accused

FALLEN: Bora being led by CBI officials in Delhi's Tis Hazari Court

in the case, Pulin Phukan, was a close associate of Bora's brother Bhola.

The minister's arrest comes as a severe blow to the Tarun Gogoi-led Congress Government. Interestingly, when he was produced in Delhi's Tis Hazari court for the first time after his arrest, Bora had accused health minister Himanta Biswa Sharma and Congress MP Mani Kumar Subba of framing him. However, on June 9, during the hearing of his bail plea, he changed his statement and put the blame on the Opposition.

When contacted, Sharma blamed the media for Bora's somersault. "I think a journalist spread this rumour. Bora never said anything against me," he says. However, political observers do not rule out the possibility of his colleagues having laid a trap for the disgraced minister. "Bora emerged as a strong leader of the north bank region of the Brahmaputra. He is

believed to be the mastermind behind the CBI probe into Subba's nationality. He was fast becoming an obstacle for Sharma," says the editor of a prominent Assamese weekly. Significantly, Gupta's Guwahati residence is just three blocks away from Sharma's. Besides, Pathak claims that Gupta's nephew Abhigyan Gogoi and Sulfa leader Diganta Saikia had approached him to contact Bora regarding the Toppo murder case. He was only "felicitating the meeting between the minister and Gupta".

For the fragmented state Opposition, Bora's arrest provides a platform to launch a tirade against the regime. "We have always maintained that Gogoi is leading a bunch of criminals and Bora's arrest has proved it. We now demand action against other ministers with criminal backgrounds," says Asom Gana Parishad MP Sarbananda Sonowal.

By dropping Bora from the Cabinet and suspending him from the party, the Congress seeks to claim moral victory. "Prafulla Kumar Mahanta continued as chief minister even when a Letter of Credit case was pending against him. But we sacked Bora within three hours of his arrest," says Rockeybull Hussain, forest minister and spokesperson of the Assam Government.

The Opposition mocks at such tall claims. "If the Government is serious about cleansing the ministry, Gogoi must immediately drop Sharma, Hussain and Gautam Roy from the cabinet," says Sonowal. The health minister, however, rubbishes such allegations and says that Sonowal should first clear his own records. "The CBI has chargesheeted Sonowal in student leader Saurabh Bora's murder case. He is now out on bail," Sharma told INDIA TODAY. He even challenges Sonowal to quote the case number if ever any case has been registered against him in any police station of the country. "If he can do so, I'll quit politics," he says.

While the mud-slinging continues, the results of the upcoming Lok Sabha polls will depend heavily on how the Congress and the Opposition handle Bora's fall from grace. The mighty former minister is not likely to fade away from the scene just like that.

by Kaushik Deka



"Bora never said I was behind his arrest. It's a rumour spread by a journalist."

HIMANTA BISWA SHARMA, HEALTH MINISTER